

How Can You Make a Good Name With God?

Public Talk No. 55

Version: v3 focused draft with experience

Target length: 30 minutes including scripture readings

Highlight key: **MAIN IDEA** / **CONTRAST OR TURNING POINT** / **ACTION CUE**

Introduction (05) 2 min

(Warm opening)

Have you ever walked past a garden and noticed a **PLEASANT FRAGRANCE** before you even saw the flower? You may stop and think, "Where is that coming from?" The flower may be small. It may even be partly hidden among the leaves. But its fragrance has already made an impression.

(Connect gently)

In a similar way, **OUR NAME CARRIES SOMETHING**. When people hear our name, it may bring thoughts to mind: "That person is honest." "That person is kind." "That person can be trusted." Of course, people do not always see clearly. Sometimes they remember unusual things too. We may try hard for years to build a good reputation, and someone still remembers the one time we tripped while carrying food at a gathering.

(Pause briefly)

But there is **ONE PERSON** whose view of our name matters more than anyone else's: Jehovah.

(State theme)

So today we will consider this important question: **HOW CAN YOU MAKE A GOOD NAME WITH GOD?** This is not only for those who have served Jehovah for many years. New ones, young ones, and those rebuilding spiritual habits can begin making a good name with Jehovah now.

A Good Name Is Valuable (07) 3 min incl. reading

(Transition to scripture)

Please turn to Proverbs 22:1.

(Read; then pause)

Read Proverbs 22:1.

(Explain simply)

The verse says that **A GOOD NAME** is to be chosen rather than **GREAT WEALTH**.

Many people spend much of life trying to make a name for themselves through money, career, education, popularity, or today, through social media. A person may spend twenty minutes arranging a photo of a cup of coffee so that strangers will think, "What a meaningful life." *Meanwhile, the coffee is getting cold.*

(Bible contrast)

The Bible gives us a strong warning example at **BABEL**. In **Genesis 11:4**, the people there said: **"LET US MAKE A CELEBRATED NAME FOR OURSELVES."** They wanted recognition, importance, and security, but they were not trying to make a good name with Jehovah. Nimrod too became a mighty and famous man, but **Genesis 10:9** says he was **"IN OPPOSITION TO JEHOVAH."** So their name was built on ambition, pride, and independence from Jehovah.

What was the result? As **Genesis 11:8** shows, Jehovah confused their language and scattered them over the earth. Their project stopped, their unity collapsed, and the name they wanted to build for themselves became connected with confusion, not honor. So the lesson is clear: **A NAME BUILT APART FROM JEHOVAH DOES NOT LAST.**

(Apply)

So the question is not, "How can I become noticed?" The better question is, **"WHAT KIND OF NAME AM I MAKING WITH JEHOVAH?"** Psalm 15:1, 2 shows that Jehovah values integrity, right conduct, and truth in the heart. So a good name with God is not built on ambition or display. It is built by **FAITHFUL CHOICES DAY AFTER DAY**.

(Transition)

But why should we especially want a good name with God?

Why Make a Good Name With God? (10) 5 min incl. reading

(New main section)

Please turn to Malachi 3:16.

(Read warmly)

Read Malachi 3:16.

(Explain the verse)

Notice Jehovah's response. **HE PAYS ATTENTION. HE LISTENS.** Those who fear him and meditate on his name are not invisible to him. The verse speaks of a **"BOOK OF REMEMBRANCE."** That is a warm expression. Jehovah remembers those who value him.

(Positive contrast)

In contrast with Babel, think of **ABRAHAM**. He did not chase fame or try to build a name for himself. He simply trusted and obeyed Jehovah. He left his homeland, followed Jehovah's direction, and lived as a man of faith. And in **Genesis 12:2**, what did Jehovah say? **"I WILL MAKE YOUR NAME GREAT."** So Abraham's good name was not self-made. It was **JEHOVAH-GIVEN**.

And that name lasted. Thousands of years later, Abraham is still remembered, not for wealth, fame, or popularity, but for **FAITH AND FRIENDSHIP WITH JEHOVAH**. **James 2:23** even calls him Jehovah's friend. That is the kind of name that truly matters.

(Encourage newer ones)

That can be very encouraging, especially for newer ones. A person may think, "I do not know much yet. I still get nervous finding Bible books. Sometimes I turn to the table of contents and hope no one notices." But Jehovah is not looking for someone to impress him with speed. **HE NOTICES SINCERITY.**

(Say; then pause)

JEHOVAH NOTICES SINCERE BEGINNINGS.

(Brief support)

Hebrews 11:6 says that Jehovah rewards those earnestly seeking him. So if someone starts to pray, starts to study, starts to attend meetings, or starts to make changes, Jehovah sees more than the outward action. He sees the heart behind it.

(Apply warmly)

People do not always see effort. They may hear one short comment at the meeting, but Jehovah may see the preparation, the prayer, and the courage behind that comment. People may see someone sitting calmly in the Kingdom Hall, but Jehovah may know it took real effort just to come.

(Motive)

Why do we want this good name with God? Not just because we owe Jehovah worship, though we do. Revelation 4:11 reminds us that all things exist because of Jehovah's will. But our main motivation is **LOVE**. Psalm 116:12 captures the spirit: **"WHAT CAN I REPAY JEHOVAH?"**

(Transition)

So how can we make a good name with God? The outline gives four practical steps: **LEARN** about Jehovah, **OBEY** his commandments, **IMITATE** his qualities, and **PRAY** to him.

How Can You Make a Good Name With God? (15) 16 min incl. readings

1. Learn About Jehovah (15) 4 min incl. reading

(Point one clearly)

Please turn to John 17:3.

(Emphasize knowing)

Read John 17:3.

(Read)

Jesus connected everlasting life with **COMING TO KNOW JEHOVAH** and the one he sent, Jesus Christ.

(Explain)

Knowing Jehovah is more than collecting Bible facts. Facts matter, but the goal is **RELATIONSHIP**. We are learning what Jehovah loves, what he hates, how he treats people, how he views us, and why his way of life is best.

(Illustrate with main picture)

A person could know many facts about a flower: its name, color, season, and soil. But that is different from leaning close, noticing its fragrance, and appreciating what it adds to the garden. Bible study should be like that. We do not just identify information. We come to **APPRECIATE JEHOVAH HIMSELF**.

(Brief support)

Psalm 119:97 shows the value of loving and meditating on Jehovah's law. So when we read, we can slow down enough to ask: **"WHAT DOES THIS TEACH ME ABOUT JEHOVAH?"** **"WHAT DOES THIS TEACH ME ABOUT MYSELF?"** **"WHAT DOES JEHOVAH WANT ME TO DO?"**

(Apply)

This is encouraging if we are newer or if we are rebuilding spiritual habits. We do not need to understand everything at once. A friendship grows through regular attention. A good name with Jehovah begins to grow as we **KEEP LEARNING** about him.

(Transition)

But learning about Jehovah naturally leads to the second step.

2. Obey Jehovah's Commandments (19) 4 min incl. reading

(Reassuring tone)

Please turn to 1 John 5:3.

(Emphasize not burdensome)

Read 1 John 5:3.

(Introduce experience)

In the **May 22, 1985, Awake!**, there is an experience about a brother named **DAVID MEYERS**.

(Curious tone)

Have you ever heard of David Meyers? Maybe some have. Maybe many have not.

But have you heard of **KAREEM ABDUL-JABBAR**? Many people have. He is remembered as one of the greatest basketball players in NBA history.

(Build interest)

Now think about this: David Meyers played for UCLA, where his team won national championships. In 1975, the Los Angeles Lakers drafted him **SECOND OVERALL**. That same year, he signed a contract worth about **1.6 MILLION**.

DOLLARS FOR FIVE YEARS. To feel the weight of that today, a modern second overall NBA pick could be worth roughly **70 MILLION DOLLARS OVER FIVE YEARS**.

And shortly after that, David Meyers was included in the **TRADE THAT BROUGHT KAREEM** Abdul-Jabbar to the Lakers.

(Clarify carefully)

Of course, that does not mean David Meyers was equal to Kareem. But just being mentioned in that kind of trade tells us something. Teams saw **SERIOUS POTENTIAL** in him. They saw value. They saw what he could become.

So when David Meyers later walked away from professional basketball, he was not giving up something small. He had already reached the NBA. He had already had a major contract. And after deciding to retire, tempting offers came in, including opportunities to continue playing for other teams and possibly receive an even larger payday.

(Pause)

But his **VALUES HAD CHANGED**.

He still loved basketball. But he came to **LOVE JEHOVAH MORE**. He valued personal study, meetings, preaching, and caring for his family. Basketball was taking him away from those spiritual responsibilities. So he **CHOSE OBEDIENCE**.

(Emphasize obedience)

That is important. His decision was not merely, "I want a quieter life." It was **OBEDIENCE SHAPED BY LOVE**.

That fits beautifully with 1 John 5:3. Jehovah's commandments are not burdensome. They help us choose what deserves first place.

David Meyers could have kept building a name in professional sports. But because he loved Jehovah, he chose obedience. And by doing that, he built something better: **A GOOD NAME WITH JEHOVAH**.

(Apply personally)

Our choices may not involve professional sports or millions of dollars. But each of us faces moments when obedience tests what kind of name we really want. So we might ask, **"WHAT IS ONE CHOICE I CAN MAKE NOW?"**

3. Imitate Jehovah's Qualities (23) 3 min incl. reading

(Point three clearly)

Please turn to Psalm 25:4.

(Read as request)

Read Psalm 25:4.

(Explain)

David asked Jehovah to make him know His ways and teach him His paths. That is a humble request. He was not saying, "Jehovah, bless the path I already chose." He was saying, **"TEACH ME YOUR PATH."**

(Develop)

Imitating Jehovah means we want more than outward obedience. We want our thinking and feelings to become closer to his. Amos 5:15 states the point simply: **HATE WHAT IS BAD AND LOVE WHAT IS GOOD**. We want Jehovah to train our moral taste.

(Anchor in Jesus briefly)

How do we see Jehovah's qualities clearly? By **LOOKING AT JESUS**. John 14:9 shows that Jesus perfectly reflected his Father. When we see Jesus showing compassion, courage, patience, and loyalty, we are seeing Jehovah's qualities in action.

(Apply)

So when we read about Jesus, we can ask: "How did he treat weak people? How did he respond to pressure? How did he defend Jehovah's name? How can I imitate that today?"

(Return to theme)

A good name with Jehovah is not just about avoiding wrong. It is about **BECOMING THE KIND OF PERSON** Jehovah is pleased to remember.

4. Pray to Jehovah (26) 5 min incl. reading

(Personal tone)

Please turn to Philippians 4:6.

(Read calmly)

Read Philippians 4:6.

(Explain)

Jehovah speaks to us through the Bible. We speak to him by means of prayer. **A FRIENDSHIP CANNOT GROW IF ONLY ONE PERSON SPEAKS.** If someone says, "We are very close friends; I listen to his messages every day, but I never reply," we would probably say, "That friendship needs attention."

(Apply)

Prayer is **REAL COMMUNICATION WITH JEHOVAH**. Philippians 4:6 tells us to make our petitions known to God. That means we can speak to Jehovah about anxieties, decisions, weaknesses, gratitude, and hopes.

(Reassure)

Some feel awkward at first. They may wonder, "What should I say?" But prayer is **NOT A PERFORMANCE**. Jehovah is not listening for impressive vocabulary. He is listening for **SINCERITY**. A child does not need polished words to speak to a loving father. The relationship is what matters.

(Brief support)

First Peter 5:7 reminds us that Jehovah cares for us. Psalm 55:22 adds that we can throw our burden on him. So prayer is not a cold formality. It is a way to rely on Jehovah.

(Specific application)

We can **PRAY SPECIFICALLY**. Not only, "Please help me be good," but, "Please help me control my speech today." Not only, "Please bless my family," but, "Please help me be patient with this family member." Specific prayers help us see Jehovah's help more clearly.

(Summarize four steps)

So the four steps work together. We **LEARN** about Jehovah by listening to him in the Bible. We **OBEY** because we trust his wisdom. We **IMITATE** his qualities because we love his ways. And we **PRAY** because we rely on him.

(Return to main picture)

Those steps are like caring for a garden. Learning gives light. Obedience protects. Imitation shapes growth. Prayer keeps the relationship alive. Over time, something beautiful forms: **A NAME WITH JEHOVAH THAT HAS A PLEASING FRAGRANCE**.

Act Now to Make a Good Name With God (31) 4 min incl. reading

(Conclusion begins)

So far we have seen that a good name with Jehovah is valuable. Jehovah notices sincere ones. And we can build that good name by learning, obeying, imitating, and praying.

(Short pause)

But when should a person start?

(Transition to scripture)

Please turn to Isaiah 55:6.

(Read with urgency)

Read Isaiah 55:6.

(Explain)

The point is clear: search for Jehovah while he may be found. **DO NOT DELAY.**

Sometimes a person may think, "I will draw close to Jehovah later, when life is less busy." But life has a way of staying busy. If we wait until everything is calm, we may wait a long time.

(Compassionate tone)

Someone may also think, "But I have made mistakes. Maybe my name with God is already ruined." Isaiah 1:18 gives hope. Jehovah invited people with serious sins to set matters straight with him. So **PAST MISTAKES DO NOT HAVE TO DEFINE THE FUTURE**. A repentant person can take **ONE CLEAN STEP TODAY**.

(Final picture)

Let us return one last time to the garden. A flower may be small and partly hidden, but **ITS FRAGRANCE CAN STILL BE NOTICED**. In the same way, your efforts may feel small: a prayer, a Bible study session, a decision to obey, a quiet act of honesty, a step toward repentance, a meeting attended even when tired.

(Warm questions)

People may not notice all of that. **BUT JEHOVAH DOES.** So ask yourself: **"WHAT DOES MY NAME MEAN TO JEHOVAH RIGHT NOW?"** And **"WHAT STEP CAN I TAKE THIS WEEK?"**

(Quiet conviction)

If we learn about Jehovah, obey his commandments, imitate his qualities, and pray to him, we can make a good name with God. And **THAT GOOD NAME IS WORTH MORE THAN ANYTHING THIS WORLD CAN OFFER.**